

The thing that we need to make sure that we retain is perspective. Missing a few days of budget tracking or letting your bank balance get a bit out of control for a few days or weeks does not have to be a life sentence – when we apply the context of the whole of the rest of our lives, it can simply be a blip. You are going to experience times when you feel like you're failing to look after your financial wellbeing, when you take your eye off the ball and start to worry about your ability to manage your money again, but what is absolutely vital is that you don't let everything lapse. It's so easy to allow your own needs to play second fiddle to those of others, but remember that if you allow your mental, emotional and financial resources to become depleted through a lack of care and attention, the effects of that will knock on to other people anyway. So, no matter how long you've allowed those habits to lapse, no matter how much dust your budgeting spreadsheet has gathered, it is always the right choice to re-engage and carry on. And the more lapses you have, the easier it will be to push yourself back in the right direction – not that I'm advocating allowing your habits to fall away too frequently, of course.

Exercise: Write your emergency plan

The final exercise in this step is to write yourself an emergency plan – something that you can refer to when it all seems to be going completely wrong. You might include actions such as enlisting your accountability buddy for a